



THE ENTRY OF FOREIGN UNIVERSITIES COULD BOOST HIGHER EDUCATION

applicants gets into an Indian Institute of Management versus one out of 10 in the case of the Massachusetts Institute of Technology, USA, according to a PricewaterhouseCoopers study. The move's supporters argue that the Government needs to promote entry of foreign universities to make up for poor infrastructure in higher education.

The entry of foreign universities, say its detractors, will turn them into elitist enclaves and exact a toll from the Government-funded public university system. The best students and teachers will be at risk of being lured away by foreign universities. This criticism cannot be wished away. India is yet to achieve the goal set in 1966 by Kothari Commission of spending 6 per cent of its GDP on education; the present commitment is to spend 5 per cent of the GDP on education in the 11th Plan. Of this 5 per cent, the country spends about 0.37 per cent on higher education as against 1.41 per cent in the US, 1.07 per cent in the UK and 0.5 per cent in China.

While the Left has been unabashedly resolute in its opposition, there are others who harbour objections in private for all their public posturing. The HRD ministry has got its first dissenting note from its own backyard. The Bill contains loopholes that could deny Indians the benefits of medical education and could even hurt the sector, the health ministry has informed the HRD. The health ministry argues that foreign universities could attract some of the country's best faculty away from public institutions by offering better salaries. It also fears that the Bill would take away its role as the nodal ministry in charge of India's regulators of medical education. These regulators like the Medical Council of India, Pharmacy Council of India, Indian Nursing Council and the Central Council of Homeopathy will have no role as the HRD ministry draft bill only mentions the University Grants Commission and its proposed successor—the National

RAID OF THE FOREIGN HAND?

PLANNING COMMISSION

- There seems to be tension between welcoming reputed foreign institutions and offering the students only Indian degrees
- Wants to know if the degrees offered by such universities are equivalent to those offered by them in their countries of origin
- Wonders whether the UGC or any other regulatory agency will monitor the foreign educational institutions

YASHPAL COMMITTEE

- The Government should be clear about the purpose foreign educational institutions are going to serve
- We can ensure best learning experience for our students even by opening doors to foreign scholars and making rules flexible
- Universities grow in organic connection with their social, cultural and geographical surroundings and cannot be transplanted from somewhere else

MINISTRY RESPONSE

Since the foreign education providers will be Indian entities, the degrees will be Indian degrees. No equivalence with foreign degrees is guaranteed.

Foreign universities will play an important role in enhancing the number of students in higher education.

"The UPA Government is creating a special education zone which could harm the interests of weaker sections and lead to the commercialisation of education."

D. RAJA, CPI LEADER

